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MORE MISSILES STRIKE UKRAINE

Starlink limits slowed Ukrainian drones. Above, airstrike damage Wednesday in Kramatorsk. **WORLD, A2**

Feds press state to withhold some voters' ballots

Officials are given 48 hours to prove the ones flagged by Justice Dept. hold citizenship.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

The U.S. Department of Justice has ratcheted up its pressure campaign on California election officials to ferret out alleged voter fraud ahead of the Nov. 3 midterm election, demanding that officials statewide prove the U.S. citizenship of thousands of voters flagged by the federal government as potential noncitizens, or withhold or set aside their ballots.

Acting Deputy Atty. Gen. Trent McCotter made the demand — which experts called highly questionable at a time when votes are already being cast — in letters to state election officials Tuesday, including Secretary of State Shirley Weber and Dean Logan, head of the L.A. County Registrar-Recorder/County Clerk's office.

The letters, reviewed by The Times, call on the state officials to respond to the Justice Department within 48 hours.

McCotter wrote that the Justice Department had provided Logan's office with a "password-protected thumb drive with a list of names the Federal Government believes are likely noncitizens who were sent a vote-by-mail ballot" for the Nov. 3 election.

"We request that you review the list within 48 hours to determine whether any citizens are listed. For individuals whom you cannot independently confirm citizenship status, we request that you immediately instruct the appropriate elections officials to segregate — not cancel — those individuals' vote-by-mail ballots until their citizenship status can be determined," McCotter wrote to both Weber and Logan.

Voters on the federal list who haven't already been sent a ballot should not be sent one until their citizenship is verified, while ballots already returned by voters on the list should not be counted until their citizenship is verified, McCotter wrote.

Weber's office did not respond to a request for comment.

Logan said his office was reviewing the Justice Department letter in coordination with Weber and California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta, but had not accessed the USB drive because state of-

[See **Elections,** A5]



ANNA MONEYMAKER Getty Images

UNDER ATTY. GEN. Todd Blanche, the U.S. is questioning the citizenship of thousands of Californians.

RISING PRICES REMAIN A MAJOR ISSUE

U.S. inflation grows in September to 3.7%, promising to play a role in midterm races.

BY CHRISTOPHER RUGABER

U.S. inflation accelerated last month as gasoline and many other goods and services became more expensive, evidence that rising prices remain an economic challenge just a few weeks before midterm elections that have focused heavily on issues related to affordability.

The consumer price index rose 3.7% in September compared with a year ago, the Labor Department said Wednesday, up from 3.4% in August. On a monthly basis, costs jumped 0.6% from August to September, the biggest gain in five months, up from a 0.4% increase the previous month.

The figures underscore the lingering impact of the Iran war on gas prices and the stubborn persistence of inflation, which has ticked higher since the war began in late February. The rise isn't all linked to oil and gas, as surging investment in data centers and AI has also pushed up prices for computer chips and the consumer electronics that use them. Elevated inflation has posed political problems for Republicans in Congress and is a challenge for the Federal Reserve, which is required by Congress to seek stable prices.

Excluding the volatile food and energy categories, core prices rose 2.6% in September from a year ago, up from 2.4% the previous month and higher than economists had expected. And they climbed 0.3% from August to September, an elevated pace that, if it continued for a year, would run well above the Fed's 2% target.

Higher inflation will probably put more pressure on the Fed to lift its key interest rate at its next meeting Oct. 27-28. Economists noted that the report showed price increases were spread more broadly across the economy than in recent months.

"The report was worse than expected," Bill Adams, chief U.S. economist at Fifth Third Bank, said in a note to clients. "Price increases were widespread ... affecting a range of durable goods, nondurables, and services."

Wednesday's report is the last major inflation data to be released before the upcoming elections. Ongoing inflation has taken a toll on

[See **Inflation,** A10]

Winds will test whether L.A. learned its lessons

By Clara Harter, Terry Castleman and Rong-Gong Lin II

Since the Eaton and Palisades fires, there has been report after report documenting how woefully unprepared city, county and fire officials were. This week's upcoming Santa Ana winds will provide one of the first major tests of whether Los Angeles has applied those painful lessons.

A red flag alert is in place across most of Los Angeles and Ventura counties from 6 a.m. Thursday through 10 p.m. Friday, with forecasters warning of sustained winds of 20 to 40 mph and gusts of 40 to 60 mph. The powerful Santa Anas will coincide with toasty temperatures of 85 to 95 degrees and low humidity rates, between 5% and 15%, across much of the region.

"There's a high risk for any new fires to grow really fast," said Ryan Kittell, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service in Oxnard.

Reviews of last year's firestorm revealed critical failures to pre-stage resources, especially in Pacific Palisades, where no engines were deployed in advance of the fire's start despite warnings of extreme weather. The city of L.A. also drew criticism for the fact that the Santa Ynez Reservoir was dry during the firestorm, while the L.A. Fire Department's own after-action report described major failures by high-ranking commanders in communication, staffing and basic wildland firefighting knowledge.

Both the L.A. city and county fire departments are strategically pre-deploying personnel and equipment in advance of this week's dangerous fire weather. The California Governor's Office of Emergency Services is also positioning additional firefighters, aircraft and equipment in Orange, Ventura, Los Angeles and Santa Barbara counties.

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass' office projected confidence that the city was better prepared to handle red flag conditions.

A spokesperson for the mayor said that all L.A. Department of Water and Power tanks that service hillside areas are full of water, and that all open-air reservoirs remain available for firefighting support — with no current concerns about water

[See **Santa Anas,** A6]

Once mighty Netflix faces headwinds

Still tops in subscribers, the firm announces layoffs amid scrutiny over its growth plans.

BY WENDY LEE

It was a crowning moment. Netflix appeared to have prevailed in an audacious $82.7-billion deal to scoop one of the industry's most prestigious studios: Warner Bros. The move seemed to cement Netflix's status as the ultimate Hollywood gate-crasher and its dominance as the leading new player in media.

Now, nearly a year later, the plotline for Netflix has dramatically changed. The streaming giant lost out to Paramount Skydance in its bid for Warner Bros. Discovery and is facing headwinds on multiple fronts.

That was underscored this week when the streaming giant Netflix began shedding 6% of its workforce, or about 1,000 jobs — believed to be the largest layoff in the company's history and exceeding the last round of job cuts in 2022, when it reported subscriber declines.

On Wednesday morning, Ted Sarandos and Co-Chief Executive Greg Peters sent a note to employees confirming the job losses, adding that the bulk of the cuts would affect the tech, product, legal and human resources teams.

"Our mission — to entertain the world — is ambitious, and delivering on it requires us to be disciplined about where we prioritize our people and resources," wrote Sarandos and Peters in the memo obtained by The Times.

The cuts mark the latest reductions across the film and TV industry. Other entertainment and media companies have slashed their payrolls, including Walt Disney Co., Paramount and Sony Pictures Entertainment, during a period of economic uncertainty in Hollywood.

But the scale of such downsizing is unusual for Netflix. Industry analysts and insiders chalk up the reversal of fortune to several factors. Although it still dominates the television business, the Los Gatos, Calif., company hasn't been able to produce enough new hit franchises to replace culture-defining shows from years past such as "Stranger Things" and "Squid Game."

At the same time, Netflix faces rising competition from rivals such as HBO Max, Apple TV, Hulu and

[See **Netflix,** A11]

Bass, Raman clash in debate

Mayor and challenger spar over police chief, Pacific Palisades fire and homelessness.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG AND DAVID ZAHNISER

The gloves came off in the final debate between Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass and Councilmember Nithya Raman this week, with the two candidates trading verbal blows over public safety, the Palisades fire and the fate of Police Chief Jim McDonnell.

Bass, now in a tough battle for a second term, portrayed Raman as someone who isn't ready to lead the city. Raman, she said, has "a tendency to take different positions on different days of the week" — and has struggled to work collaboratively with others at City Hall.

"Now is not the time to turn the city over to Nithya Raman," she said.

Raman, for her part, said the mayor had been "missing in action" during the massively destructive Palisades fire in January 2025 and the more recent Lineage cold storage warehouse blaze in Boyle Heights. City Hall, Raman said, is now experiencing "a crisis of trust."

"We cannot afford another four years of decline, of mismanagement, of excuses," Raman said.

Tuesday night's hourlong event in Universal City,

[See **Debate,** A6]

Floods carry fire risks for EVs

Water, especially if salty, can cause batteries to short-circuit and combust even weeks after exposure, experts say

By Suhauna Hussain



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

MOTORISTS take a risk on a Laguna Beach street on Oct. 9. El Niño is expected to bring more flooding.

Damage from a week's worth of high surf and El Niño-related storms brought many warnings from officials. Beaches were closed. Homes were evacuated and red-tagged.

But one alert was targeted to a specific audience: owners of electric vehicles that were submerged by the flooding.

"If you notice smoke, hissing, popping or unusual heat, move away immediately and call 911," the Laguna Beach Fire Department said. "Do not attempt to move the vehicle or extinguish the fire yourself." It also warned that if the car had been partially submerged it shouldn't be driven or charged, even if it appears to operate normally.

California is the epicenter of America's EV market, representing about 19% of all new car sales, according to a UC Davis study. Now, California faces an exceptionally

[See **Batteries,** A7]

Dodgers return home in NLCS

For full coverage of Game 3 against Milwaukee, go to *latimes.com/dodgers*.

Justices' ruling favors the GOP

High court says political parties can have lower rates for campaign ads. **NATION, A5**

Grappling with student's death

Family asks LAUSD to bring back campus police, saying teen was bullied. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny and hot.
L.A. Basin: 93/68. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

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